

Use Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI)[™] To Understand Intent

When giving feedback, remember the simple SBI method: clarify the situation, describe the behavior, then share the impact. Then, if you like, you can inquire to explore intentions vs. impact.

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How To Use the SBI Method To Give Feedback & Explore Intent vs. Impact

When somebody disappoints you, fails to deliver what you expected, or lets you down in some way, what do you do?

If you're like most people, you make assumptions that are usually not positive: *"That guy isn't a team player ... he's lazy ... doesn't care ... or just doesn't get it."*

And then you take action: *"I'll just find a workaround ... get somebody else to do the work ... rethink responsibilities ... initiate discipline."*

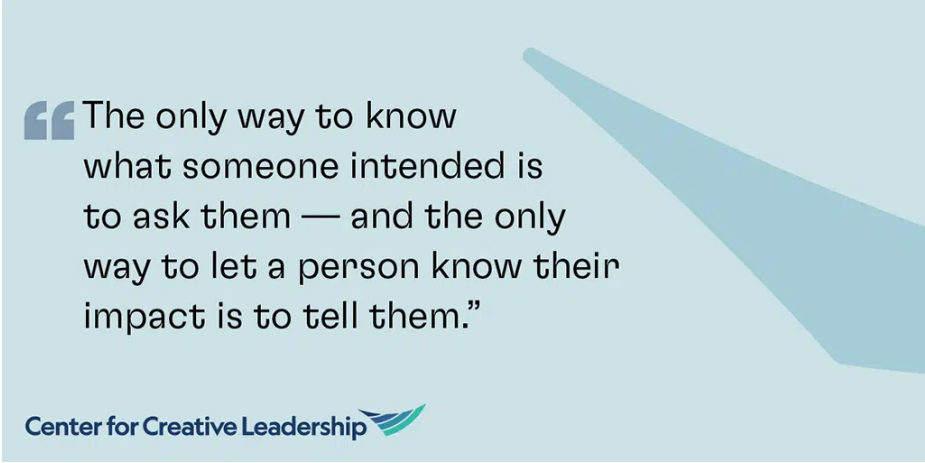
We often don't even realize that we create stories about people in our heads, especially when they disappoint us. This happens all the time. We see a behavior, assume we know why the other person acted a certain way,



and react based on those assumptions.

But many difficulties can be avoided by having a clarifying discussion. Though people usually *intend* to do the right thing, sometimes something gets scrambled or misinterpreted along the way, and the impact is far from what they intended.

The only way to know what someone intended is to *ask* them — and the only way to let a person know their impact is to *tell* them. These important conversations rarely happen, though, and we move through our days in a tangle of misperceptions and actions, based on incorrect assumptions.



“The only way to know what someone intended is to ask them — and the only way to let a person know their impact is to tell them.”

Center for Creative Leadership

So, how do you, as a leader, [tackle difficult conversations](#) to find out why a person chose to behave a certain way? We recommend using our research-based, widely-recognized method for delivering feedback, **Situation – Behavior – Impact, or (SBI)™**.

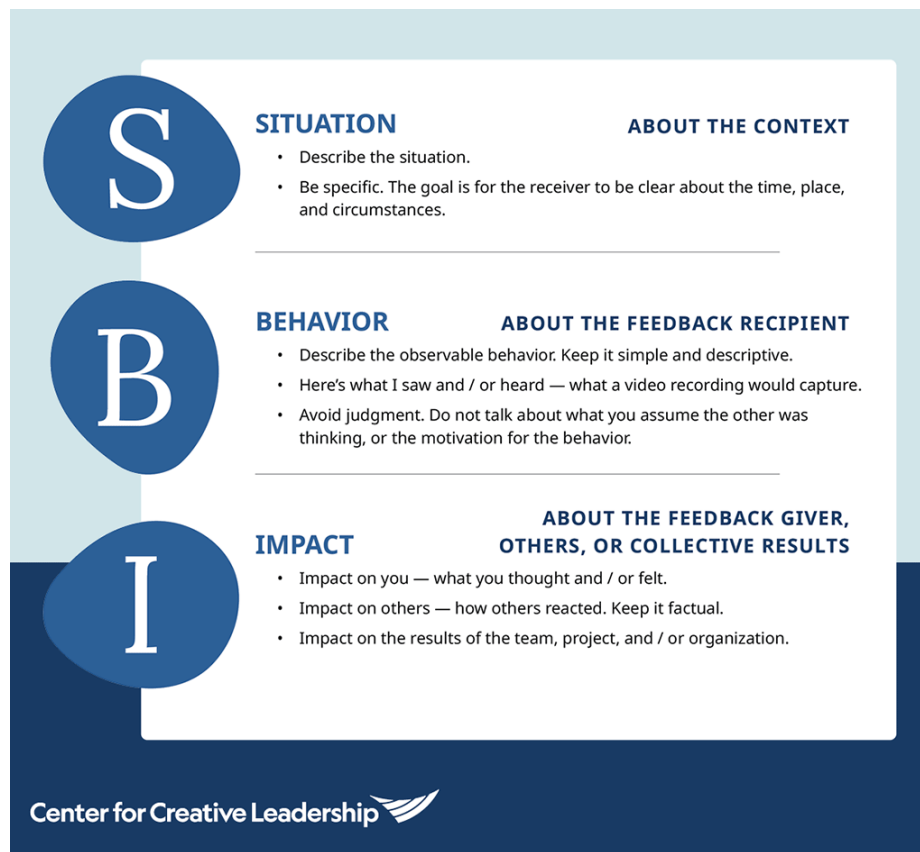
The benefits of using SBI to give feedback and explore impact vs. intent are clear: Using the SBI method helps *both* parties become more comfortable with the feedback process. [Our research on feedback shows](#) that SBI reduces anxiety around giving feedback, as well as the defensiveness of the recipient in hearing it. We also found that employees rate managers as more effective when they give feedback more frequently.

What Does Situation-Behavior-Impact Mean?

The Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) method for giving someone feedback is simple and direct. You simply:

1. Clarify the **Situation**,
2. Describe the specific **Behaviors** observed, and
3. Explain the **Impact** that behavior had on you.





How Can You Use Situation-Behavior-Impact With Team Members?

The [SBI feedback model is helpful when holding talent conversations](#) with employees or when giving [different types of feedback](#), as in these examples:

1. Situation:

Describe the specific situation in which the behavior occurred. Avoid generalities, such as “last week,” as that can lead to confusion.

- Example: *“This morning at the 11 am team meeting ...”*

2. Behavior:

Describe the actual, observable behavior. Keep to the facts. Don't insert any opinions or judgements.

- Example: *“You interrupted me while I was telling the team about the monthly budget,”* instead of *“You were rude.”*

3. Impact:

Describe the results of the behavior. Because you're describing exactly what happened and explaining your true feelings — not passing judgement — the listener is more likely to absorb what you're saying. If the effect was positive, words like “happy” or “proud” help underscore the success of the behavior. If the effect of the behavior was negative and needs to stop, you can use words such as “troubled” or “worried.”

- Example: “*I was impressed when you addressed that issue without being asked*” or “*I felt frustrated when you interrupted me because it broke my train of thought.*”

The success of Situation-Behavior-Impact is enhanced when the feedback, which is one-way, is accompanied by an inquiry about intent, which makes the conversation two-way.

Build Trust by Exploring Intent vs. Impact With SBII

Extend the SBI Method for Feedback To Include Inquiring About Intent

Extending the Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) tool for delivering feedback to be Situation-Behavior-Impact-Intent (SBII) allows you to have a conversation to learn more about the intentions behind a person’s actions or behaviors. Inquiring about intent can demonstrate [compassionate leadership](#) and prevents veering off in the wrong direction based on faulty assumptions. To do this, simply add a final step to Situation-Behavior-Impact:

4. Intent:

Inquire about the person’s original intentions. Inviting them to share where they were coming from helps you understand more about the other person’s experience of the situation and explore the gap together between intentions vs. impact, building greater trust and understanding.

- Example: “*What were you hoping to accomplish with that?*” or “*What was going on for you?*”

Then [actively listen](#) to the other person as they share their perspective. Simple solutions usually follow.

Asking about intent is also where good coaching starts. When you inquire about intention, motivation, or what’s behind an action, you’re essentially engaging in [a coaching conversation](#) — one that can make a positive difference well before a performance review or disciplinary conversation.

So, the next time you need to give someone some feedback, rather than making assumptions, just have a conversation with them. And remember to use Situation-Behavior-Impact-Intent (SBII).

Based on Research by



Bill Gentry, PhD

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Bill’s research at CCL focused on examining what leaders, particularly first-time managers, can do to be successful in their work and life, and to avoid derailment. He’s the author of [Be the Boss Everyone Wants to Work For: A Guide for New Leaders](#) and co-author of the guidebook [Developing Political Savvy](#).

**Stephen Young, PhD**

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Steve led our experimentation with new analytic approaches and methodologies, including [CCL Fusion](#), a predictive analytics tool that links people data with business data to inform leadership development investment. He also led research and product development in the areas of user-driven feedback tools, virtual coaching tools, and big data and analytics.



At the Center for Creative Leadership, our drive to create a ripple effect of positive change underpins everything we do. For 50+ years, we've pioneered leadership development solutions for leaders at every level, from community leaders to CEOs. Consistently ranked among the top global providers of executive education, our research-based programs and solutions inspire individuals at every level in organizations across the world — including 2/3 of the Fortune 1000 — to ignite remarkable transformations.

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